Turning wooden fruit

Colwin Way gets right to the core of using jam chucks when turning fruit...

Jam chucks were among the first things I was taught how to make and use when I started turning as an apprentice more than 30 years ago. They solve a host of work-holding issues and are capable of holding a wide variety of projects, from bowls to wooden fruit. This gives the turner scope to push their turning limits and also allows them to start thinking outside of the confinements of conventional chucks.

I have been demonstrating the making and using of these chucks to woodturners all over the country for a number of years. These demonstrations always produce the same reaction and generate many questions. They solve a lot of holding problems and create a method of holding your work without leaving any marks.

To demonstrate the use of a simple jam chuck we're going to make a batch of fruit. Wooden apples and pears are a project most turners will try, but rarely do I see anyone use the jam-chucking method. This is a shame because not only do I find this a lot quicker but also – and most importantly – when turning the main shape it allows you to see the outside form having nothing hidden by a screw chuck, which is by far the most common method used. Apples and pears may look to be a fairly simple form to turn, however, get the shape wrong and they simply won't look right.

Over the years I've turned thousands of pieces of fruit and I am always excited by the variety of colour we have to work with in our timbers. I try as much as possible to use unusual pieces of timber. This doesn't have to mean exotic, but timber where an unusual grain or colour comes through; it also gives us the opportunity to use those small pieces of timber that would normally be discarded from the workshop.

PHOTOGRAPHS BY COLWIN WAY

COLWIN WAY

Colwin started turning aged 13 and has since gone on to teach the craft and wishes to continue to give people confidence to try the wonderful hobby for themselves. Colwin was born and grew up in Lyme Regis, a small seaside town in the southwest of England and is still living in the area with his wife Vicki and two sons, Finley and Charlie.

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